



LOST GEMS: Lack of security and proper documentation at the Rabindra Bhavan museum tells a sad story

thousands of students and scholars, including foreigners live. Choudhury believes the university should not be treated like a tourist spot. "It becomes a burden on us. But at the same time, it is impossible to separate the university from Tagore's legacy," he says. He also agrees that very little has been done to present Shantiniketan in its true spirit to the scores of visitors who come to pay homage to Tagore. There are no official guides and ready reckoners to let people know the importance of each building, monument or sculptures on the site.

Another cause for concern is the fact that precious works of art—sculptures by legends like Baij—are in the open all over the university premises. Little is being done to prevent the damage that being in the open can cause. On this there is a difference of opinion between the traditional and the modern. Many of the artists, including Tagore, wanted their works to be kept in the open, in harmony with nature so a storm of protest erupts in the campus whenever attempts are made to build protective enclosures around the artefacts or even move them to more secure environs.

The new regime at the Visva Bharati, under Vice-Chancellor Rajat Roy, promises to make many changes. Security is being looked into, the museum is being renovated and a catalogue of Tagore's paintings being prepared. Manuscripts and rare documents are being digitalised. However, the key to all these plans is the money that the university will get from various sources.

Tagore's abode of peace has changed with the times. Controversies have dogged its steps as it has grown from a 1901 dream to a Central university. Those running the show believe it should be treated like that—as a modern institution rooted in history. But there are those who believe Tagore's ideals are all that is needed to keep the university in good shape. In that eternal tussle, one can only hope that Visva Bharati awakes to that heaven of freedom that Tagore had dreamt of. ■

MISSING TREASURES

Many rare artefacts have disappeared from the university over the years

- Tagore's Nobel medallion.
- A *baluchari* sari worn by Tagore's wife Mrinalini Devi for their wedding and a gold ring belonging to Maharshi Debendranath Tagore, Tagore's father.
- Paintings by Tagore, Nandalal Bose and others are missing from Kala Bhavan.
- Sculptures by Somnath Hore (Vietnamer Khoto—the wounds of Vietnam) and Bose (Bodhisattva).
- Murals by Surendranath Dutta (Mother and Child in front of Buddha), Benode Behari Mukherjee (Sunflower and various other landscape panels), Bose (Bamboo Grove and Portrait of Behari), Baij (various landscapes and figurative motifs).

ity is lax in the university is not really true. We try to do our best. We are also upgrading our security system taking into account the recommendations made by a high-level committee that was formed by former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam. But you have to keep in mind that the university really has no demarcated boundary, no proper wall and no real campus in the true sense. Tagore wanted it to be a free environment and it has grown accordingly. Tagore's experiment has grown far beyond imagination. It is difficult to maintain a balance between his ideals and modern needs," says Choudhury.

On January 6 this year, Saswati Pal, a student of Sangeet Bhavan was shot dead inside her hostel by an outsider, Amaresh Kundu, giving rise to concerns about the security of a place where

